

CLASS 10 CBSE ENGLISH - FIRST FLIGHT

Chapter 1: A Letter to God • Poem: Dust of Snow

Study Material Includes

NCERT exercise solutions • Oral Comprehension Check • Thinking About the Text • Thinking About Language • Paragraph/stanza explanations • Themes • Character sketch • Poetic devices • Important quotations • Word meanings • Extract-based questions • Short & long answers • Value-based questions • Additional CBSE-oriented questions

PART I - A LETTER TO GOD

G.L. Fuentes

A. Oral Comprehension Check - NCERT

1. What did Lencho hope for?

Answer: Lencho hoped for a good rainfall because his ripe corn crop needed water. He believed that the rain would bring a good harvest and provide food and income for his family.

2. Why did Lencho say the raindrops were like 'new coins'?

Answer: Lencho compared the raindrops to new coins because the rain promised a good harvest. He imagined that each drop would contribute to the growth of his crop and therefore to his family's prosperity.

3. How did the rain change into a hailstorm?

Answer: At first, the rain was gentle and promising. Soon, strong winds began to blow and large hailstones started falling. The hailstorm continued for a long time and completely destroyed Lencho's crop.

4. What happened to Lencho's fields after the hailstorm?

Answer: The entire crop was destroyed. The field looked white as if covered with salt, and there was nothing left that could be harvested. Lencho and his family faced severe financial hardship.

5. What did Lencho write in his letter to God?

Answer: Lencho wrote that he needed one hundred pesos so that he could sow his field again and survive until the next crop. He had complete faith that God would help him.

6. Why did Lencho become angry after receiving the money?

Answer: Lencho had asked God for one hundred pesos but received only seventy pesos. Instead of doubting God, he assumed that the post-office employees had stolen the remaining thirty pesos.

B. Thinking About the Text - NCERT

1. What are the raindrops compared to and why?

Answer: Lencho compares the raindrops to new coins. The big drops resemble ten-cent and five-cent pieces in his imagination. The comparison also shows his excitement because he expects the rain to bring a rich harvest.

2. How did the rain change into a hailstorm?

Answer: The weather suddenly became violent. A strong wind rose and large hailstones began falling. The storm continued for about an hour, destroying the entire crop and turning Lencho's hope into despair.

3. How did the hailstorm affect Lencho's family?

Answer: The hailstorm destroyed their only source of livelihood. They were left without a crop and therefore without money for food or for sowing the field again. Lencho became deeply worried about his family's future.

4. Why did Lencho have complete faith in God?

Answer: Lencho was deeply religious and believed that God could see everything and help people in need. After the crop was destroyed, he considered God his only remaining hope, so he wrote directly to Him for financial assistance.

5. Who read Lencho's letter and what did he do?

Answer: The postmaster read the letter. He was impressed by Lencho's faith and did not want that faith to be destroyed. He collected money from his employees and friends and sent seventy pesos to Lencho in an envelope signed as 'God'.

6. Why did Lencho call the post-office employees 'a bunch of crooks'?

Answer: Lencho had absolute faith that God had sent the full amount he requested. When he received only seventy pesos, he assumed that God could not have made the mistake. Therefore, he wrongly concluded that the post-office employees had stolen the remaining thirty pesos.

C. Thinking About Language - NCERT

1. What do the words 'a bunch of crooks' mean in the story?

Answer: The expression means a group of dishonest people or thieves. Lencho uses it to accuse the post-office employees of stealing part of the money he believed God had sent.

2. What does 'an ox of a man' mean?

Answer: It describes a very strong, hardworking and physically powerful man. Lencho is portrayed as a sturdy farmer who works hard in his fields.

3. Find examples of words related to nature and weather.

Answer: Examples include rain, wind, clouds, hailstones, storm and field. These words help create the setting and show how strongly Lencho's life depends on natural conditions.

4. Identify expressions showing Lencho's faith.

Answer: Expressions such as 'God knows', 'God willing', and Lencho's decision to write directly to God show his deep and unquestioning faith.

D. Paragraph-wise Explanation

Beginning: Lencho watches the sky and waits for rain.

Answer: Lencho is a hardworking farmer whose livelihood depends on his crop. He looks at the sky with hope because he needs rain. His faith in nature and his expectation of a good harvest are established at the beginning.

The hailstorm destroys the crop.

Answer: The promising weather suddenly becomes destructive. The hailstones ruin every plant in the field. Lencho becomes devastated because the family's entire livelihood has been destroyed.

Lencho writes to God.

Answer: Instead of giving up, Lencho turns to God. His faith is so strong that he believes God will understand his suffering and send him money to restart farming.

The postmaster helps him.

Answer: The postmaster is moved by Lencho's faith. He collects money and sends it anonymously as if it has come from God. This act demonstrates human kindness and compassion.

Lencho misunderstands the help.

Answer: When Lencho receives seventy pesos, he believes God has sent the full amount he requested. Because the envelope contains less than one hundred pesos, he assumes that the postal employees stole the rest. The irony is that the people he calls dishonest are actually the people who helped him.

E. Character Sketches

Lencho

Answer: Lencho is hardworking, simple, honest and deeply religious. He has complete faith in God and turns to Him during a crisis. However, his faith is also somewhat blind because he refuses to consider any explanation other than divine intervention. His accusation against the post-office employees creates the story's central irony.

The Postmaster

Answer: The postmaster is kind, compassionate and generous. He is impressed by Lencho's faith and wants to protect it. He collects money and sends it to Lencho anonymously. His action represents human goodness and sympathy.

F. Themes

Faith

Answer: Lencho's unquestioning faith in God drives the entire story. Even after losing everything, he believes that God will help him.

Human kindness

Answer: The postmaster and his colleagues demonstrate compassion by contributing money for a farmer they do not personally know.

Irony

Answer: The greatest irony is that Lencho calls the very people who helped him 'crooks'. The reader knows the truth, while Lencho does not.

Nature and human vulnerability

Answer: The farmer depends on the weather. A sudden hailstorm can destroy months of labour, showing how vulnerable agricultural life can be to nature.

G. Additional Theoretical Questions - A Letter to God

1. Why was Lencho's house located on the crest of a low hill?

Answer: The location allowed Lencho to see his fields clearly. The story also uses the hill and open landscape to establish the rural setting of the farmer's life.

2. Why was Lencho satisfied with the rain at first?

Answer: He needed rain for his crop. The rainfall appeared to promise a good harvest and therefore a secure future for his family.

3. Why did Lencho compare the hailstones to 'new silver coins'?

Answer: The hailstones looked bright and valuable to him at first. The comparison also contrasts sharply with the later destruction caused by the same weather.

4. What does the postmaster's reaction reveal about his personality?

Answer: It reveals that he is empathetic and generous. He is moved by Lencho's faith and makes an effort to help him even though Lencho is a stranger.

5. Is Lencho's faith admirable or unreasonable?

Answer: His faith is admirable because it gives him hope during a crisis. However, his final accusation shows that his faith becomes unreasonable when he refuses to consider the possibility that people, rather than God directly, may have helped him.

6. Explain the irony in the ending.

Answer: The post-office workers are the people who provide Lencho with seventy pesos, yet Lencho believes they stole the missing thirty pesos. The reader knows that his 'crooks' are actually his benefactors.

7. What is the main message of the story?

Answer: The story highlights the power of faith and human kindness while using irony to show how blind faith can distort a person's understanding of reality.

PART II - DUST OF SNOW

Robert Frost

A. Stanza-wise Explanation

Stanza 1

Answer: The poet describes a moment when a crow shakes snow from a hemlock tree onto him. Both the crow and the hemlock tree are traditionally associated with unpleasant or gloomy images, yet this ordinary natural event affects the poet positively.

Stanza 2

Answer: The falling snow changes the poet's mood. The moment that seemed insignificant actually saves part of his day from being wasted in regret. The poet becomes happier and feels that he still has time to enjoy the day.

B. Thinking About the Poem - NCERT

1. What is a 'dust of snow'? What does the poet say has changed his mood?

Answer: The 'dust of snow' refers to fine particles of snow shaken from the hemlock tree by a crow. This small natural event changes the poet's gloomy mood and makes him feel refreshed.

2. How does Frost present nature in the poem?

Answer: Frost presents nature as simple but powerful. A brief encounter with a crow, a tree and snow has the ability to transform the poet's mood. Nature therefore becomes a source of emotional renewal.

3. What is the significance of the crow and the hemlock tree?

Answer: Both are traditionally associated with darkness or unpleasantness. Frost deliberately uses them to show that even things considered negative can produce a positive experience and change a person's mood.

4. What does 'saved some part of a day I had rued' mean?

Answer: It means that the poet had been regretting or feeling unhappy about part of his day. The unexpected snowfall improved his mood and prevented the entire day from being wasted in sadness.

C. Poetic Devices - Dust of Snow

Device	Explanation
Rhyme scheme	ABAB in each stanza.
Alliteration	Repetition of initial consonant sounds, such as the repeated 's' sounds in phrases involving snow and shook.
Assonance	Repetition of vowel sounds contributes to the poem's musical quality.
Symbolism	The crow, hemlock and snow carry symbolic associations, while the snowfall represents a sudden positive change.
Imagery	The poem creates a clear visual picture of snow falling from a tree onto the poet.
Enjambment	Ideas flow from one line to the next, creating a natural movement.
Contrast	Dark associations of the crow and hemlock contrast with the positive effect of the snow.

D. Central Ideas & Themes - Dust of Snow

Central idea

Answer: A small and unexpected moment in nature can transform a person's mood. The poem shows that even an apparently insignificant experience can bring hope and prevent a bad day from being completely wasted.

Theme of positive transformation

Answer: The poet moves from sadness or regret to a more positive state after the snow falls on him. The change is sudden and simple.

Theme of nature's healing power

Answer: Nature does not always need to be spectacular to affect us. A tiny natural event can refresh the mind and restore emotional balance.

E. Important Words & Meanings

Dust

Answer: Very fine particles; here, tiny particles of snow.

Hemlock

Answer: A poisonous tree; its mention contributes to the darker imagery.

Rued

Answer: Regretted.

Shook

Answer: Moved suddenly or caused something to fall by shaking.

Mood

Answer: A person's emotional state.

F. Additional Questions - Dust of Snow

1. Why does Frost choose a crow rather than a beautiful bird?

Answer: The crow has traditionally negative associations. By using it, Frost shows that even an apparently unpleasant creature can become part of a beautiful and positive experience.

2. Why is the title 'Dust of Snow' appropriate?

Answer: The title focuses on the small amount of snow that falls on the poet. This tiny event becomes powerful enough to change his mood.

3. What is the message of the poem?

Answer: We should remain open to small moments of beauty and change. An ordinary experience can restore hope and improve our emotional state.

4. How does the poem show that nature can influence human emotions?

Answer: The falling snow immediately changes the poet's mood. Nature acts as a quiet source of comfort and renewal.

5. Explain the contrast in the poem.

Answer: The crow and hemlock have gloomy associations, while the effect of the snow is positive. This contrast reinforces the idea that positive experiences can arise from unexpected sources.

G. Extract-Based Questions

"The way a crow / Shook down on me / The dust of snow / From a hemlock tree"

What fell on the poet?

Answer: Fine particles of snow fell on the poet.

From which tree did it fall?

Answer: It fell from a hemlock tree.

What caused it to fall?

Answer: A crow shook the snow down from the tree.

"Has given my heart / A change of mood / And saved some part / Of a day I had rued."

What change occurred?

Answer: The poet's mood became more positive.

What had the poet regretted?

Answer: He had been regretting or feeling unhappy about part of his day.

What is the central idea of these lines?

Answer: A small natural event can transform sadness into a better mood.

H. Combined CBSE Exam-Oriented Questions

1. Compare Lencho's faith with the poet's response to nature in 'Dust of Snow'.

Answer: Lencho has a deep and direct faith in God and depends on divine help after the destruction of his crop. The poet in 'Dust of Snow' experiences a quieter kind of transformation through nature. Both texts show that hope can emerge during difficult moments, although the source of that hope is different.

2. How does irony make 'A Letter to God' effective?

Answer: The irony comes from the difference between what Lencho believes and what the reader knows. Lencho believes God sent him money, but the money actually comes from the postmaster and his colleagues. He then calls these helpers dishonest. This unexpected misunderstanding gives the story humour while also highlighting Lencho's blind faith.

3. Both 'A Letter to God' and 'Dust of Snow' show a change in the central character's emotional state. Explain.

Answer: Lencho's emotional state changes from hope to despair after the hailstorm, and then to renewed confidence when he receives money. In 'Dust of Snow', the poet moves from regret and sadness to a better mood after a small natural event. Both texts show how circumstances can quickly influence human emotions.

4. What values can students learn from the postmaster?

Answer: Students can learn compassion, generosity, empathy and the importance of helping people in distress. The postmaster does not mock Lencho's unusual letter; instead, he respects his faith and takes practical action to help him.

5. What is the significance of the title 'A Letter to God'?

Answer: The title highlights Lencho's extraordinary faith. His letter is addressed directly to God because he believes that God can solve his problem. The title also prepares the reader for the story's central theme of faith and the irony surrounding the response to the letter.

I. Value-Based Questions

1. If you were the postmaster, would you have helped Lencho? Explain the value involved.

Answer: Helping a person in distress reflects empathy and social responsibility. The postmaster's decision shows that kindness can preserve another person's hope and dignity.

2. What should we learn from the poet's experience in 'Dust of Snow'?

Answer: We should not assume that a difficult day is completely lost. Small positive experiences can change our mood, so we should remain observant and open to the good around us.

3. Is blind faith always beneficial?

Answer: Faith can provide hope and strength, but blind faith can also lead to misunderstanding. A balanced approach combines hope with reason and awareness of facts.

J. Very Short Questions for Revision

Who wrote 'A Letter to God'?

Answer: G.L. Fuentes.

Who wrote 'Dust of Snow'?

Answer: Robert Frost.

What was Lencho's profession?

Answer: He was a farmer.

What destroyed Lencho's crop?

Answer: A severe hailstorm.

How much money did Lencho ask God for?

Answer: One hundred pesos.

How much money did he actually receive?

Answer: Seventy pesos.

Who arranged the money?

Answer: The postmaster with contributions from the postal staff and others.

What did Lencho call the postal employees?

Answer: A bunch of crooks.

Which bird appears in 'Dust of Snow'?

Answer: A crow.

Which tree appears in the poem?

Answer: A hemlock tree.

What changed the poet's mood?

Answer: Dust of snow falling on him.

What does 'rued' mean?

Answer: Regretted.

K. Important Quotations & Meanings

"The big drops of rain began to fall."

Answer: The rain initially brings hope because Lencho's crop needs water.

"These aren't raindrops falling from the sky, they are new coins."

Answer: Lencho sees the rain as a sign of prosperity and a good harvest.

"There was not a leaf left on the trees."

Answer: The hailstorm has caused complete destruction.

"God: of the money that I asked you for, only seventy pesos reached me."

Answer: Lencho assumes that God sent the money and someone else stole the rest.

"Has given my heart / A change of mood."

Answer: The small snowfall has transformed the poet's emotional state.

L. CBSE Answer-Writing Tips

For 2-3 mark answers

Answer: Write the direct answer first, then give one or two supporting details from the text. Avoid unnecessary storytelling.

For 5-6 mark answers

Answer: Begin with the central point, develop it with 3-4 relevant textual details, and finish with the message/theme. Keep the answer logically connected.

For extract questions

Answer: Identify the context, answer each part directly, and use the exact idea from the passage rather than making unsupported assumptions.

For value-based questions

Answer: Connect the textual situation with a clear human value such as empathy, courage, faith, responsibility or rational thinking.